# A Letter to God

## The big idea

**A Letter to God** by **G.L. Fuentes** is a short story about a poor farmer whose faith in God is so complete that he writes a letter to Him asking for money. It is a story about **faith**, **kindness** and a delicious **irony**: the very people who help Lencho are the ones he ends up calling thieves.

**ONE-LINE SUMMARY**

A hailstorm destroys Lencho's crop; he writes to God for 100 pesos; the postmaster collects 70 pesos and sends it signed "God"; Lencho angrily accuses the post office employees of stealing the missing 30.

## Summary

- **The setting:** Lencho's house stands alone on the crest of a low hill, in a valley in Mexico. From there he can see his field of ripe corn dotted with flowers, which promises a good harvest. The only thing the earth needs is a downpour.
- **The rain and the hail:** The rain comes, and Lencho compares the big drops to **"new coins"** — ten-cent and five-cent pieces. But a strong wind brings huge **hailstones**, which he calls **"frozen pearls"**. For an hour the hail falls, and the field becomes white as if covered in salt. Lencho says the hail has left them worse off than a **plague of locusts**: "we'll go hungry this year".
- **The letter:** That night, Lencho's only hope is God, "whose eyes see everything, even what is deep in one's conscience". On Sunday he writes a letter asking God for **100 pesos** to sow his field again and live until the new crop comes. He addresses it **"To God"** and posts it.

- **The postmaster:** The postmaster, a fat, amiable man, first laughs, then is moved by such faith. Not wanting to shake it, he decides to answer the letter. He collects money from his employees, gives part of his salary, and asks friends to contribute. He manages to collect only **a little more than half — 70 pesos**. He puts the money in an envelope, signs it **"God"** and sends it.
- **The ending:** Lencho shows no surprise at receiving money (such is his confidence), but he becomes **angry** on counting it. He writes a second letter asking God for the remaining **30 pesos**, but requests that it not be sent by mail, because **"the post office employees are a bunch of crooks"**.

## Characters

| Character | Traits |
|---|---|
| **Lencho** | Hardworking farmer, knows his field well, has **unshakeable faith in God**, simple and naive, but also ungrateful and suspicious of people. |
| **The postmaster** | Kind, generous, sensitive; respects faith; helps without wanting credit. |
| **Lencho's family** | Wife and sons who work in the field; they share his despair after the hail. |

## Themes and literary devices

- **Faith:** Lencho's faith is total. He trusts God completely but does not trust human beings.
- **Kindness of strangers:** The postmaster and his staff give their own money to an unknown man.
- **Irony:** The people who helped him are called crooks. The postmaster was proud of his "good deed" while Lencho thought it was theft. This is **situational irony**.

- **Imagery and simile:** raindrops as "new coins", hail as "frozen pearls", the field white "as if covered with salt".
- **Contrast:** the hope of the morning vs the sorrow of the evening; physical storm vs the "storm" in Lencho's heart.

**NUMBERS EXAMINERS ASK**

Asked for: **100 pesos**. Received: **70 pesos**. Asked for again: **30 pesos**. The postmaster signed the letter **"God"**.

**LENCHO IS NOT A CHEAT**

Some students write that Lencho was greedy. He asks only for what he needs to replant and survive. His flaw is naive mistrust of people, not greed.

## Message and value points

- Faith gives strength in hard times, but blind faith without common sense can lead us to wrong judgements.
- True charity is done quietly, without expecting thanks.
- We should be grateful for help and not judge people hastily.

**LIKELY QUESTIONS**

"What was the irony in the story?" "Describe the postmaster's character." "How did the hailstorm affect Lencho?" "Why did Lencho get angry on receiving the money?" Always mention the 70/30 numbers and the phrase "bunch of crooks".

## Quick recap

- Author: G.L. Fuentes; set in rural Mexico.
- Rain = new coins; hail = frozen pearls; worse than locusts.

- Letter "To God" for 100 pesos; postmaster sends 70 pesos signed "God".
- Lencho calls post office employees "a bunch of crooks" — the central irony.

## Practice questions

1. Lencho compared the large drops of rain to
   (a) frozen pearls (b) new coins (c) salt crystals (d) ripe corn
2. How much money did Lencho ask God for in his first letter?
   (a) 30 pesos (b) 70 pesos (c) 50 pesos (d) 100 pesos
3. Why did the postmaster decide to answer the letter?
   (a) He did not want to shake the writer's faith in God (b) He wanted to make fun of Lencho (c) It was his official duty (d) Lencho was his friend
4. The hail left the field white "as if covered with"
   (a) snow (b) cotton (c) salt (d) flowers
5. What was Lencho's reaction on counting the money?
   (a) He thanked the postmaster (b) He was surprised (c) He was angry because 30 pesos were missing (d) He returned the money
6. The central irony of the story is that
   (a) God sent less money than asked (b) the postmaster was a thief (c) Lencho never received any money (d) the people who helped Lencho were called crooks by him
7. Lencho said the hail had done more harm than
   (a) a flood (b) a plague of locusts (c) a drought (d) a fire
8. Describe the character of the postmaster in "A Letter to God".
9. "A Letter to God" is full of irony. Explain with examples.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. a 4. c 5. c 6. d 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes